

1900–1914

SIMPLER SILHOUETTES

While the period between 1900 and World War I saw a great transformation in women's silhouettes, certain aspects were slow to change. The fashionable, wealthy lady was still expected to change outfits several times a day, and her body continued to be moulded into the desired shape by rigid corsetry. There was, however, a gradual shift from a curvy, hourglass figure – with its emphasis on a tiny waist – towards a more tubular outline. The practical tailor-mades (suits) that had been introduced in the previous century remained fashionable and heralded the move towards simpler garments. Turn-of-the-century ribbons and lace, and ruches and pleats were slowly discarded to reveal not only a more pared-down style but also women's feet.

LINGERIE

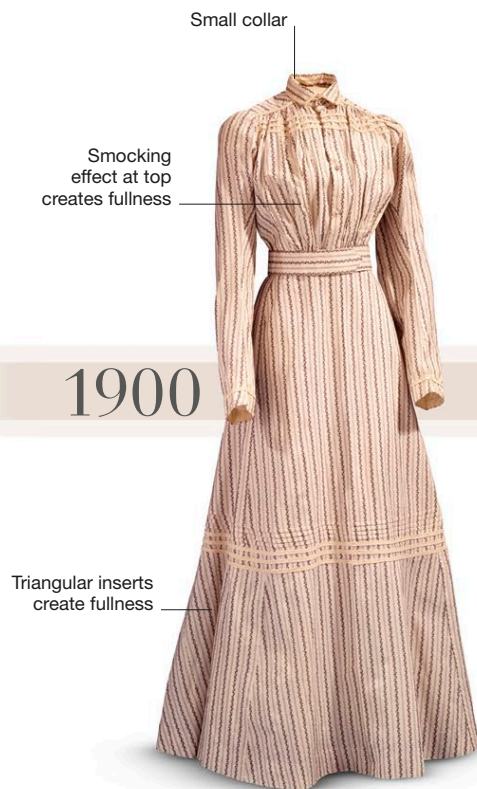
Flimsy, soft, and highly decorated chemises and camisole-and-knickers combinations were worn underneath rigid constructions that moulded the body into the fashionable shape. The flat-fronted corset induced the "S-bend" with the upper body pushed forward while the hips were thrown back. Corsets left the busts largely unsupported so that bust bodices and a variety of bust improvers had to be enlisted to create the fashionable, impressive "mono-bosom".

Towards the end of the first decade corsets slid down the body, shortening above the bodice and lengthening below. Gradually, women were allowed to stand upright again.



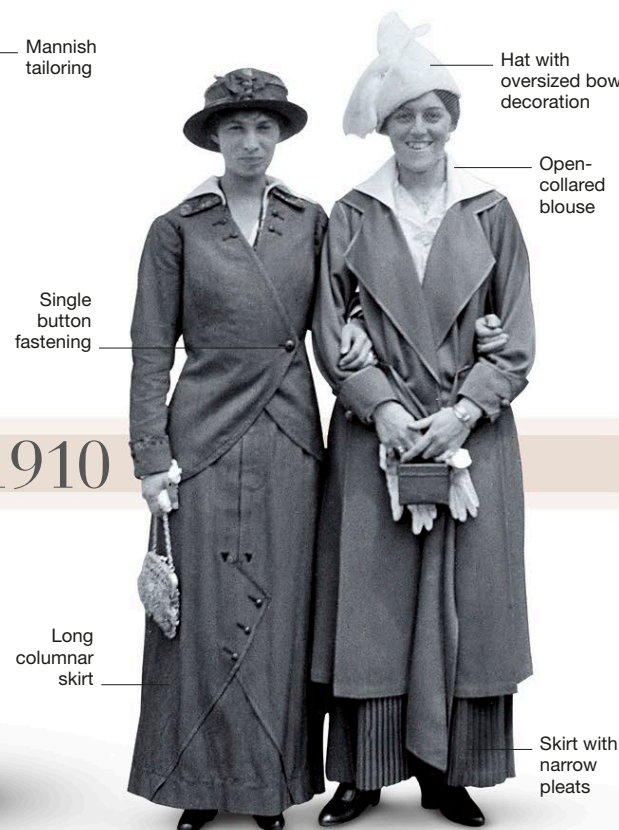
1908

House of Creed This French house began as a tailoring business in London in the 18th century and specialized in riding habits and tailor-mades. This suit shows the move away from the S-shape silhouette towards a more tubular outline.



1900

Shirt and waist This striped cotton skirt and waist (blouse) might look relatively informal but would have been worn over body-shaping undergarments to produce a narrow waist. The vertical pleats of the blouse create fullness around the bust.



1910

Ship shape For travel aboard a liner, two young Americans wear loosely fitted jackets with straight skirts. This new look was more comfortable and practical than the narrow-waisted dresses of the preceding years.